Worksheet B: Beautiful Fakes and Source Criticism

Name: _____ Date: _____

Task 2: Anatomy of a beautiful fake

in class after the reveal, individual work, 10 min.

The following news item is **fictitious** and was constructed for this exercise, following the pattern of the "beautiful fake" from the moment of wonder. Mark every feature that *creates* credibility, and note for each whether it *proves* anything.

> **Juggling makes you smart: ten minutes in the morning boost memory by 23.7 percent**
>
> People who start the day with juggling balls learn faster. That is the finding of a new study that experts have been discussing for weeks. "The effects are impressive", says Prof. Dr. H. Lindner, learning researcher and author of several self-help books. Participants who juggled before learning vocabulary retained on average 23.7 % more words. More and more schools are already considering juggling breaks. This fits what educators have long suspected: movement and thinking belong together.
>
> *(Fictitious teaching material, Unit 4. Person, study and figures are invented.)*

Feature	Does it prove anything? What is missing?

Task 3: Source criticism in five steps

homework

During the wrap-up, enter the five steps that the group works out on the board in the left column (for comparison: handout). Then apply the checklist to two entries of your annotated bibliography from Unit 3. Tick what you have checked and note whether your judgement has changed.

Step	Source A	Source B
1	☐	☐
2	☐	☐
3	☐	☐
4	☐	☐
5	☐	☐

Has your judgement changed? Why?

Task 4: Discussion: 500 citations

homework, max. 1 page

"A study has 500 citations. What does that say about its quality?" Write a structured counter-argument against the assumption that many citations mean high quality. Structure: (a) the thesis in its strongest form, (b) at least three counter-arguments, each with evidence or an example, (c) what citations *do* tell us, (d) your conclusion: how would you assess quality instead?

Task 5: Diary of wonder

homework

Describe a pattern you noticed this week (chance, statistics, news, everyday life). What did you expect, what did you see, and how could you test whether the pattern is real?